

PART ONE

By hekapider

Up in the wild hills off the coast, the sun glinted down through the trees. The ground was a mess of cracked stone, splintered wood, and debris.

Bandits groaned on the ground where they lay strewn amongst the rubble, having been thoroughly wrecked.

Amongst the wreckage, standing triumphantly, were Hekapider—a whirlwind of chaotic, infectious energy—and her husband, Baoyu, the long-suffering anchor of calm.



Baoyu offered Heka a steadying hand as she navigated out of the rubble. As they left, regional officers arrived to make the arrests. The duo didn't stay, having accomplished their goal. Their serious need for a bath was their new priority. As they descended the hilltop towards their horses, which had been left safely at the

base, a few busybody locals approached.

"Bless you, heroes! We can never repay you for your help. May you be blessed with never-ending joy and peace."

Heka beamed and accepted their kind words. Baoyu nodded in respect. Neither accepted the gifts offered in their direction.

"We appreciate the gesture, but must decline. We travel too much and wish to not overload our poor horses. Please keep it for yourselves. We want for nothing."

From behind them, the locals shouted out, "May you share a hundred years of unbroken love, harmony, and unending loyalty!"

Heka chuckled softly and shook her head before nudging her husband's shoulder softly... "It's a shame we can't seem to find anyone competent to join us these days. It would be nice to share the load... give you a break."

Baoyu stretched out his arms before throwing one around Heka's shoulder as they approached their horses. "We've been in the area for not even a week. I'm sure you'll find us some new trouble soon enough. Plenty of opportunities to meet more wanderers."

Travelling with others usually began with optimism, but there were admittedly too few who could keep pace with plans that went off the rails based on the whims and imagination of a tiny avatar of chaos wielding an umbrella.

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Their new goal was to travel through the valley to the next town with a proper market and inn where they could take a proper bath. The mood was light and bright. The pair of wanderers joked and told stories they'd both heard from each other more than a few times, finishing each other's sentences whenever the storyteller lost their own train of thought. The chatter of the birds and rustling of creatures in the underbrush even seemed to have a joke to share.

Then, as they entered the village, as if a curtain had been dropped, the world seemed to go eerily quiet. This early in the day, the town ought to have been bustling... instead.

Baoyu: "The market is too dead for an early afternoon." He looked towards the few

stalls that were open. "They're terrified."

Heka looked around and, indeed, merchants whispered as their eyes darted around, seeming on edge and ready to bolt. Passersby kept their heads down and rushed to their destinations. Windows shuttered. Doors barred closed.

"The rumours we heard on the road. Seems the old magistrate really is bleeding them dry with new 'trading fees'... I believe you were right, my dear, trouble is heading right towards us."

Despite the serious nature of the situation, a glint of anticipation burned under Heka's skin. A stranger might have found it unsettling, but anyone who knew her would know she simply loved putting so-called 'nobles' in their place... or taking them out of their place. Whichever the situation called for.

As they tied off their horses outside of an inn, they continued to hear more whispers of the situation.

"...vanished. She couldn't afford their new fees, and right in front of the neighbours, they carted her away. It's been two days and still no sign or word of her."

"That's the third stall this week. At this rate, there will be no market for them to rob, then what?"

"Bleeding us dry. Maybe I should take up my mother's offer to go back to visit my family near the capital."

Heka and Baoyu looked at each other with unspoken understanding and headed inside to book a room for the week. Once they stabled the horses and unloaded their belongings safely in their room, they settled in the common room for tea and food, which they barely touched. Instead, they focused on listening...

And because too long without trouble was not possible when Heka was in town, not five minutes after their first sip of tea, there was a sudden thud as the front door was kicked open.

There was a collective flinch from the locals as four thugs wearing cheap and worn versions of yamen uniforms strutted in, hands already wielding clubs. The man leading them had what looked to be a proper official's sword.

The thugs—despite their official attire, a much more fitting word to describe them—strutted up to the proprietress. "Time's up! No more freebies. Pay your

arrears or we'll have no choice but to take you into custody!"

Baoyu put a calming hand on Heka's hand to stop her from reacting too soon. As she looked at him, he shook his head. "Not yet."

Heka, despite Baoyu's well-intentioned restraint, was squirming to deal with these bad guys in a proper jianghu fashion.

However, before she could twitch, there was a flurry of action! In the seeming blink of an eye, clubs and a sword were neatly piled on a vacant table and all four men were unceremoniously flung out the door. Outside, they groaned in the dirt where they had landed neatly in a row.



A young woman with striking purple/green hair and an elegant demeanour casually returned to her table in a shadowed corner. Raising her cup to her lips, she drank the remainder of her tea before leaving without a word to drag the thugs away.

Heka's eyes sparkled.

Baoyu knew that look...

Throughout the village, the pair heard about this stranger.

She was Zu Weiyun. She had arrived in the area weeks ago. She stepped in to stop the weak from being picked on, then left before anyone could thank her, let alone give her any rewards or gifts.

"A true heroine." Heka's eyes sparkled with admiration. Baoyu patted her head. "Let's not get ahead of yourself, dear."

Zu Weiyun began to notice that Heka and Baoyu "coincidentally" appeared around her. More often, it was in a helpful capacity, but usually Heka was barrelling in as a chaos goblin and Baoyu brought sanity and rationality to balance the scales. The pair complemented each other well.

What caught Weiyun off guard was Heka's very direct flirtations right in front of her husband. Her husband, who said nothing and just smiled fondly as he reined in his very excitable wife.

Unable to make sense of the strangely magnetic pair, Weiyun stuck to her usual song and dance and simply made her exits as quickly as possible.

With Weiyun's very violent reaction to the magistrate's thugs, she didn't stay in any one village too long. She quickly moved on to the next village, sometimes skipping one or two to not be obvious in her movements.

So imagine her surprise when, two weeks later, a very familiar pair were suddenly in the room next to hers at the shabbiest inn she'd ever seen.

Wei couldn't help but peer into the room next to hers, where the door had been left ajar.



"...what?"

Baoyu was sitting at the small table, poring over a map and making very neat and elegant marks of key locations. He looked up at Weiyun briefly before gesturing at her to keep her voice down. Over on the bed, starfished and half covered by the thin blanket, was Heka. Snoring.

"Booked it 3 days ago," he said matter-of-factly. As though it was a silly question to be asking at all while being polite enough to answer.

But Wei didn't think it was silly. She'd been so careful to keep her movements unpredictable. That this very strange pair were able to not only stay on her trail, but predict it in advance... "...how?"

Baoyu shrugged. "...she had a hunch."

A hunch!! Wei would have laughed at the ridiculousness of the situation if the reality of it weren't sitting right in front of her. And snoring.

Fighting fate's weird sense of humour seemed to be a losing battle, so Weiyun decided that going with the tide would, at least for the moment, spare her the frustrations of trying to dodge her pursuers. It would just come down to her to keep things professional. THAT she could at least manage.

Heka was delighted to find Wei sitting at the table with Baoyu when she woke from her nap. Determined to make a good impression, she moved to join them at the table... and, tangled in the blanket as she was, fell to the floor instead.

Wei couldn't help but let out a small laugh at how ridiculous Heka looked. She didn't find it adorable at all. Not even a little. And if she noticed Baoyu studying her reaction thoughtfully as if he *knew* something, it was all his imagination.

Then they got down to business.

The region's magistrate, it had been learned, was affiliated with a less-than-honourable sect. A few high-ranking members had once trained in proper sects before being expelled for dishonourable conduct. Now they recruited thugs and hired themselves out as enforcers when new policies would otherwise be unpopular. Policies such as unnecessary fees for merchants, stall owners, and other business owners.

Though Wei was still hesitant, she accepted that it was a good idea to work with

Heka and Baoyu. The conspiracy there was far larger than expected, and the help of like-minded, though certainly quirky, heroes was indeed welcome.

While the trio was brainstorming, the weather became turbulent and the wind picked up. Baoyu didn't react. Wei went on alert. Heka poured a fourth cup of tea, and quick as lightning, a white, fluffy blur snatched the cup from her hand. A



white-haired woman with nine fox tails was perched elegantly on the wooden chest at the end of the bed. She sipped the offered tea.

Wei was mid-reaction to go on the defensive until Heka greeted the stranger, "Shifu." Baoyu politely greeted them as well. "Shifu GNS."

Wei relaxed... slightly.

GNS eyed Wei, clearly evaluating. She looked at Heka. "This one, eh?"

Heka smiled shyly.

GNS approached Wei, who stiffened, and circled around her. "Good qi. Balanced." GNS walked around Wei. She nodded in approval. "Could certainly handle your particular brand of chaos." GNS sat back down as Heka refilled the teacup. "Duel now or later?"

Before Wei could question anything, Baoyu spoke up. "Later. Still too soon."

GNS nodded. "Understandable. Goodness knows this disciple of mine took time to grow on you even."

GNS waved her hand dismissively. "Next time then." And as quickly as she had

arrived, she was gone.

Weiyun couldn't help but wonder who exactly these people were... Some kind of drunken immortal with a violent aura had just casually shown up for tea with the adorable chaos incarnate while having small talk with said adorable being's very pretty, very smart husband. (No point in denying that they were so obviously attractive.)

And what was this about a duel? Who in their right mind would duel this GNS??!

Ever observant, Baoyu seemed to have picked up on Weiyun's thoughts and, without waiting for questions to be asked out loud, answered, "She's patient. No need to stress about the duel until you're ready."

"No need to stress about the duel until I'm ready," Wei parroted back in disbelief.

Heka simply nodded as if the whole situation were simply a matter of course. "It's just a formality, really. My shifu might seem as though they take it too seriously, but they aren't actually going to try to kill you or anything."

Weiyun, not wanting to dwell on the insanity of the notion, placed her hands firmly on the table. "Forget it. We're just going to talk in circles about this when we have other priorities that need our focus."

Baoyu chuckled under his breath before smoothing his hands over the map, and Heka muttered something incoherent under her breath... But back to the task they went.

Baoyu's thoughts on strategy were quite impressive. Even with a map that lacked detail, he was able to break down various paths for action depending on what they encountered on site. Heka was able to provide shift rotation schedules. Apparently, arriving 3 days before Weiyun had resulted in her wandering off to gather intel. Mostly, she hid in trees to observe and eavesdrop.

"Bad Guy A is clearly crushing on Bad Guy B, but B is married and VERY in love with his wife. And very monogamous," Heka made a face at that. "Which is a shame because I think they could make it work." All that time eavesdropping and the amount of gossip she had collected... This was only one of many tangents Heka went on while she debriefed the others.

A couple of late nights were followed by a day and night of rest... the trio was finally

ready to take down an evil sect and a corrupt official.

Baoyu's strategy worked perfectly. It even took into account when Heka went rogue and improvised some bafflingly effective diversion with flower petals and flash bomb pellets. This confused and distracted the bad guys, giving Baoyu and Wei the perfect opportunity to take them down.

It went without saying... they totally won. Saving the day! (Fight is glossed over because I can't write that to save my life 😊)

And true to form, Wei took off before any words of congratulations could be uttered in her direction.

As she walked along a path away from the town they had occupied together, thoughts of the past few weeks flooded her mind so much that she didn't even realize that Heka had caught up with her. Baoyu followed 10 paces behind with their horses.

"You really don't want to travel with us?" Heka asked, doing her very best not to pout.

"I like being alone," Wei answered, since this had always been her answer. Though there was a seed of doubt as to whether it was really true anymore.

"I think you'd like travelling with me. And you get along really well with Baoyu."

"Not sure I'd survive it."

"You definitely would. I only ever like exceptionally competent people."

Wei looked... uncertain. Her worldview had been shaken, and she had yet to catch herself up or process...

Baoyu chose that particular pause to catch up with them. "Give the poor woman some time, Heka." His tone was affectionate and amused. Wei would have found him aggravating if he weren't so... probably right, but she'd never admit it in front of him. At least not yet.

Heka pouted but relented. "We're heading towards the big lake a few days north of here. When you change your mind..."

"When? You're sure about that?" She wanted so badly to resist, but more and more,

she was realizing where fate was leading her.

"I suspect we'll linger in that area for a while. Something about a drowned ghost-bride... should be fun," Baoyu mentioned casually.

Without a word, he handed off a horse lead into Wei's hand before hoisting Heka up onto the second and settling himself behind her and heading north.

"And just so you know," Heka shouted back with a wave as they rode away at a slow walk, "Starburst isn't a gift. I expect her to be returned in perfect health when you catch up!!"